(the ex-MP was convicted—for the first time ever—in a four-year-old kidnapping and extortion case) just days after he announced his intention to contest, but Srikala's entry has made it a three-cornered contest. The BSP candidate is currently the zila parishad chairman of Jaunpur and has an edge—even in the 2019 Modi wave, Jaunpur had voted for the elephant (the party symbol). The Thakur disaffection against Dhananjay's arrest and the 22 per cent Dalit and 11 per cent Muslim vote make the contest even more interesting.

Indeed, the Thakur/ Rajput anger against the BJP and the Muslim discontent with the SP are the twin weapons in the Bahujan party's arsenal this election. Mayawati has lost no occasion to rub it in, as she did in the Moradabad LS seat. "The SP has given the ticket to a Hindu candidate in a seat where the Muslims are in a majority while the BJP has ignored the Rajputs in west UP. The BSP is the only party fielding candidates taking in the community's strength and local interests," she said at a rally here.

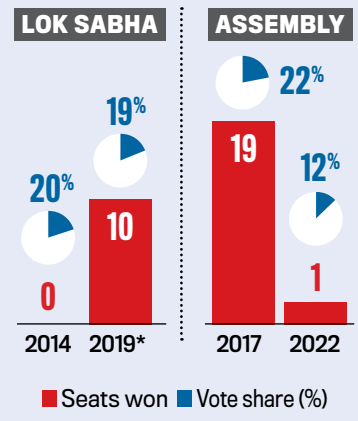
The BSP's selection of candidates may indeed upset calculations in several seats. The BJP may feel the pinch the most. In the past two elections, the saffron party's social engineering moves had led to a consolidation of the non-Yadav OBC and non-Jatav Dalit vote, which, along with its traditional forward caste base, had made it unstoppable in UP. This phalanx could see cracks this election.

To cash in on the Thakur/ Rajput resentment against the BJP, Mayawati has fielded Rajendra Singh Solanki from Gautam Buddh Nagar, Sripal Singh from Kairana, Kuldeep Bhadouria from Kanpur and Nandkishore Pundhir from the Ghaziabad seat. Meanwhile, setting off a few tremors in the SP's Muslim base, it has fielded almost a dozen candidates from the community, including Majid Ali from Saharanpur, Dr Mujahid Husain in Amroha, Mohammad Irfan Saifi in Moradabad and Zeeshan Khan in Rampur. The BSP has also caused a flutter in Badaun, where senior SP leader Shivpal Yadav is planning to send son Aditya to the Lok Sabha, by fielding former MLA Muslim Khan. For good measure, the BSP has also announced full support to building the "new Babri Masjid" whenever it comes up.

Mayawati and the BSP had been written off after the party's disastrous showing in the 2022 assembly election (it got just 12 per cent of the vote and has just one MLA, Umashankar Singh from Rasara, Ballia). Reinventing the party strategy has hence been crucial, the focus being on rebuilding the confidence among the core Dalit voters, leveraging the discontent among the other communities, and hoping that Muslims will come onboard again. The party also seems to have changed its motto, from '*Sarvajan hitai, sarvajan sukhai* (Everyone's welfare, everyone's happiness)' to '*Bahujan hitai, bahujan sukhai*', indicating a return to its core values. "Both the BJP and SP are now wary, for the BSP ticket-holders are hurting them in several seats," says Shilp Shikha Singh, political analyst and assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, adding that the party was on the brink. "The BSP can't afford another forgettable election...they had to send a strong message to the cadre and party ideologues that the game isn't over yet."

IN THE MIX

BSP vote share has been falling, hitting a nadir in '22



*Vote share figures rounded off; *alliance with SP*

THE BSP HAD BEEN WRITTEN OFF AFTER THE DISASTROUS SHOW IN THE 2022 ASSEMBLY POLLS. REINVENTING THE PARTY STRATEGY HAS HENCE BEEN CRUCIAL

The Brahmin community has also been co-opted in this "disruptive move", many of them BJP turncoats. So, in Aligarh, Hitendra Kumar a.k.a. Bunty Upadhyay, takes on Satish Gautam, the two-time MP who is facing anti-incumbency and the ire of the family of the late CM and Lodh leader Kalyan Singh. Similarly, in Dhaurahara, Shyam Kishor Awasthi gets the ticket, while Sachidanand Pandey holds the elephant symbol aloft in the Ayodhya Lok Sabha seat. Former BJP district unit president, Dayashankar Mishra, has been fielded from Basti. Meanwhile, in SP bastion Mainpuri, party chief Akhilesh Yadav's wife Dimple Yadav suddenly finds herself in a tough battle after the BSP replaced its candidate, Gulshan Dev Shakya, with ex-MLA Shiv Prasad Yadav.

Mayawati's nephew and BSP national coordinator Akash Anand has been the campaign face across the state, addressing rallies alone. As the poll battle heats up, he has been in the thick of things, accusing the BJP-ruled Centre of being a "government of terrorists" and getting booked in the bargain. BSP state president Vishwanath Pal claims the party's "unexpected results" will shock everyone on June 4 when the results are announced. Other party functionaries, who didn't want to come on record, were not so confident about the numbers, but one thing they were sure of—"everyone will realise the power of Behenji" in UP politics again. ■